from outside the local reality. In this chapter, we make a preliminary attempt to go beyond these approaches. Our starting point was the recognition that, first of all, we need to listen to local actors. Based on their distinct perceptions, we can reconstruct the way the Brazilian presence in Angola and Mozambique is expressed. We interviewed a wide range of governmental actors, scholars, and representatives of private companies, social organisations, trade unions and international bodies. From different areas and opinions, we aimed to identify their insights about the incursion of Brazil into their countries.

Some of the results are briefly reviewed in this chapter, which is organised into three topics: (a) we attempt to identify the main advances towards the Brazilian incursion in Angola and Mozambique, the network of actors and the institutional arrangements involved in it; (b) we aim to reflect upon the state's differentiated role in both countries and the ambiguous, sometimes conflicting, relations established between the Brazilian projects and actors involved; and (c) finally, we problematise new forms of 'South–South indebtedness' and the potential consequences for the country's development. Our investigation points to the need for building instruments for participation and democratisation – and the strengthening of counter-hegemonic projects involving these distinct countries – in order to promote the effective development of Brazilian and African societies. From our perspective, this is a challenge to be faced if we intend to advance towards the strengthening of the South–South cooperation as a project of integration based on solidarity and the promotion of integral development, as announced in the official discourses.

Brazil's political-economic relations in Angola and Mozambique

The most remarkable aspect of the Brazilian presence in Angola and Mozambique is related to the actions of the Brazilian construction companies and extractive industry. Angola leads as the main destination of Brazilian private investment and Odebrecht is the company most mentioned in the interviews. Besides construction, Odebrecht's operation in Angola includes, for example, sanitation services and garbage collection, agricultural production (Capanda Agro-industrial Center–PAC), diamond mining and supermarket management. The company is also notorious for its advertising signs in the streets of Luanda and its entrepreneurial and social accountability actions. Due to its strong presence in several economic sectors and the bonds established with the higher circles of the Angolan political powers, as stated by many interviewees, Odebrecht today is 'almost Angolan'. According to an interviewee, 'the company has already had a consolidated position in the country'[5] and has established direct and solid